

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=991frMkq9C4&t=1168s>

Finding Rizal in a Time of Barriers

Speaker 1: 00:00

In my family, we grew up with this story about a young Filipino who came to live in my great grandfather's house in Willemsfeld. The stories of this visitor are part of our family legacy, our heritage. This young Filipino stayed in my grandfather's house only a few months. But generations later, I feel I know this man personally. His name was Jose Rizal.

Speaker 2: 01:08

Doctor Ulmer, tell us about this Jose Rizal Strache. And it says here. Can you read it for me? It's in German.

Speaker 3: 01:18

Jose Rizal, 1861-1896, National Hero of the Philippines, finalized the last chapter of his critical novel *Noli me Tangere* in this house during a time when he was guest of pastor Ulmer.

Speaker 2: 01:41

And that was in 1886.

Speaker 3: 01:44

That was in 1886, was it?

Speaker 2: 01:45

In February. This passion project started out quite simply, a tour of the German town of Willemsfeld early in 2019. I was accompanied by Dr. Fritz Haak Ulmer. Together were tracing a small but memorable part of a journey that had taken place more than a hundred years ago.

Speaker 3: 02:12

This is the house where Rizal stayed. If the view from the window, so it must have been on this side of the house.

Speaker 2: 02:19

It's a beautiful home.

Speaker 3: 02:21

My grandfather grew up. Yes, he was the vicar. He was the vicar for this village.

Speaker 2: 02:28

Dr. Ulmer just happened to be the great grandson of Carl Ulmer, a Protestant pastor who for three months in 1886 was host to Jose Rizal when he visited Germany. I knew at once that there was a story to tell. Here a local team was put together and plans were made to leave for Germany in May of 2020. But then Covid happened. Lives lost, fears, anxieties, priorities rearranged, and a new normal of barriers everywhere. But I still felt the story was worth telling.

In August 2020, amidst the longest lockdown in the world, the local team met with members of the Philippine Embassy in Germany to discuss ways in which the story could be told without the need for foreign travel.

Speaker 4: 03:37

The tentative title for the documentary is Searching for Jose Rizal in a Time Barriers. And because that's exactly what we're living with now, barriers.

Speaker 2: 03:52

After all, Rizal himself had lived his life in a time of barriers. Barriers of race, religion, colonialism and discrimination. A lifetime of obstacles and limitations. But because of his personal convictions, he had broken down all these barriers and come home. So should this story. But first, a lesson in history and in the context of Rizal's journey through Europe, a journey that began after he completed his studies at the University of Santo Tomas in 1882.

Speaker 5: 04:47

The Rizal family was not exactly mayaman, but my kaya. The existing land situation in the Philippines in the late 19th century would show that many of these mayakaya were not hacienda owners, but were renters renting the pieces of land from the vast domain of the friar lands. And so Rizal's family was one of those inkilinos who rented the land, but they had to pay the friar owner. But that meant that you have to have the favor and approval of the friar owner. At the same time there were very rich Filipinos who just bombed around in the European capitals. And Rizal took note of that. Particularly because Rizal had to depend upon hard earned money from the lands through Paciano, his older brother. And once he tried to apply in the medical services of Madrid and found that red tape. Getting a job as a beginning doctor in Spain was so much he just abandoned the initiative. And then he found out Spain is not much better than the Philippines. He saw a Spain that is inextricably leading itself to a civil war in the third decade of the next century.

Speaker 4: 06:53

The first trip to Europe was basically for him to study. But when you read the letters, you will find out that when he arrived in Europe and he didn't know what to think. So there is this very interesting exchange between Paciano and Rizal. Will you become a lawyer? Will you become a doctor? Will you become, you know, study agriculture? In the beginning they didn't quite know what it was. Rizal arrived in the winter of 1886 in Heidelberg and. And he stayed there for three months. We know of what happened to him there because his first letter was his letter to his sister Maria talking about how Germans decorate their home.

Speaker 2: 07:40

In the vault of the National Library is a gift from Hans and Fritz Haak Ulmer. The so called Ulmer collection was given by the great grandsons of Pastor Ulmer to the Philippine nation in 1961. This collection consists of many treasures, all of which speak of the high regard in which Pastor Ulmer held Jose Rizal.

Speaker 3: 08:07

The Ulmer collection letters are. You know, after Rizal left Willemsfeld, he exchanged 12 letters, six postcards with the Ulmer family, with the pastor.

Speaker 2: 08:19

With the pastor who's your great grandfather.

Speaker 3: 08:21

Yes. And also some. Some postcards are addressed to my grandfather.

Speaker 2: 08:26

Fritz ullman, who was 14 years old.

Speaker 4: 08:28

Who was 14.

Speaker 3: 08:29

Yes, yes.

Speaker 2: 08:30

Who told you these stories?

Speaker 3: 08:32

These stories were told me by the 14 year old Fritz Ulmer.

Speaker 4: 08:36

We do not know how he got in touch with Pastor Ulmer. We just have a letter from him saying I want to study German in this little town, because I hear you speak a good type of German without an accent. And he wanted to learn high German. And we are fortunate that the drawings that he did in Germany were actually donated to the Philippines in 1961. And they were personally brought by Fritz and Hans Haack, who are the grandsons of Pastor Ulmer. And I guess the Ulmers also knew how important Rizal was. So they actually kept the things Rizal found toilet humor funny. In the 19th century, the biggest sensation in Paris, which Rizal probably watched, was La Petomene. It was a man who performed in the Moulin Rouge. He could control his window. Then he had another drawing which shows two naughty children, two naughty boys. And these naughty boys were. They went out to steal apples from some neighbor. And the boys went, stole the apples. Then when they were running away, they had to cross a little stream. So one jumped off and the other one, when he jumped, fell into the water. When I gave a talk, he in Germany, and I flashed this on the screen. The Germans immediately said, that's Max and Moritz. And this was a popular children's storybook that many German people used. One of the things that is not very well known is that also, I think in 1961 or around that time, Heidelberg, as a gift to the Philippines, gave one of the fountains, which is now in Luneta. It's rather unfortunate that people don't know about it. And this is the tragedy of Rizal. You have this family, this German family that for two generations tried to remember him. And

you have in the Philippines a nation that does not read him. I mean, Rizal wrote a lot. He left us with 25 volumes of writing that nobody reads.

Speaker 2: 11:07

More than just objects of Rizaliana. The Ulmer collection is a vital clue to the personality of Jose Rizal. It is also a clue into the personality of Pastor Carl Ulmer and his admiration for Jose Rizal. Pastor Ulmer and Jose Rizal would not have met had Rizal never embarked on his first journey to Europe. It was in Paris where Rizal first studied ophthalmology under the famed surgeon Louise de Wecker.

Speaker 1: 11:52

With respect to the study of the ailment of the eye, I am doing well. I know now how to perform all the operations in Germany. I am told that this is taught well. But one has to be registered and pay a sum of \$10 a month. If I see in effect, that the cost of living is cheap, I will have myself registered in 6 months. I hope to speak German, study a profession, continue my specialty.

Speaker 2: 12:30

In 1886, Rizal moved to Heidelberg, Germany, to further his ophthalmology studies. He would spend the next six months as an assistant in the eye clinic of another famed ophthalmologist, Dr. Otto Becker.

Speaker 5: 12:49

I think his happiest times in Europe were in Germany. He was in his element there.

Speaker 1: 13:00

I practice in the hospital and examine the patients who come every day. The professor corrects our mistakes in diagnosis. I help in curing. And although I do not see as many operations as I did in Paris, here I learn more of the practical side. I plan during the spring of 1887 to return again to Paris and observe the operations of Dr. De Wecker, who seems to me very superior to all the others I have seen. From there I can return to the Philippines and open a decent eye clinic.

Speaker 3: 13:34

This is the old ophthalmology hospital in Heidelberg where Rizal trained for about six months. New methods of ophthalmological surgery. And supposedly the method that was used here is the method Rizal later used on his mother of the operation he did in Colombia.

Speaker 2: 13:59

Dr. Ulmer, there's another marker of Dr. Rose Rizal here in Heidelberg. What is this? Is this a residence?

Speaker 3: 14:06

This was the resident in the first night on February 3rd. And he stayed in that home for four weeks.

Speaker 2: 14:14

It was a period of great productivity, both as a scientist and doctor, as well as a poet and a writer.

Speaker 3: 14:26

Rizal Ufer. You know Rizal. On 23 April 1886, Rizal wrote a poem, *Alas flores de Heidelberg*, in Spanish. And he describes the here in Heidelberg. And he describes the mountain, the *Königstuhl* and the Holy Ghost mountain on the other side. And he describes flowers that blossom on the bank of this Neckar river. And they remind him of the flowers in the Philippines. *Am weges Rheim am Necker Ufer in Waldes schatten undes schlosses alten Mauren omen brach arenad oysachte als erbambien murmurava cantos.*

Speaker 2: 15:56

Telkunik shtul el mana dora y consultivia lumbre anima el valle el bosque ila espe sura el saluda es e sol aun en su aurora alque en su.

Speaker 5: 16:10

Patria in el cenit fulgura y contada.

Speaker 2: 16:15

Queldia cuando cojilla al borde del sendero.

Speaker 4: 16:20

Recount the words he said as with great care. Between the pages of a worn out book he pressed the flexible petals that he took. Carry, carry o flowers, my love to my loved ones Peace to my country and its fecund loam, faith to its men and virtue to its women, health to the gracious beings that dwell within the sacred paternal home.

Speaker 2: 16:49

Kung kayo aydumating NASA aming dalampasigan anghalikong NASA inyo. Malik salah. At hindina malilimut ang akibat naluning ning. More than just a tribute to the beauty of Heidelberg's gardens in spring, the poem was truly Rizal's love letter to home.

Speaker 5: 18:01

Rizal's spirit lifted at the beauty of the flowers, him confronting the actual, objective reality of the flowers. But Rizal's spirit also lifted because his memory of his mother country is like that. At a time when the flowers and the plants of the Philippines our spirit had been crushed, our bodies insulted, raped.

Speaker 2: 18:46

Perhaps it was his longing for some kind of a home, some sort of family connection, that eventually led Rizal from the boarding houses of Heidelberg to the small town of Wilhelmsfeld. Here he found lodging in the vicarage of Pastor Karl Ulmer.

Speaker 1: 19:08

I have been told that the inhabitants of Willemsfeld do not speak correct German, but a dialect. If I were not afraid of imposing upon your kindness, I would ask you, if possible, to let me live with you instead of with someone else. For I shall not only live with respectable family whose friendship I value so highly, but I will also speak good German, which to me is the main thing.

Speaker 2: 19:33

The Ulmer house is now a private residence and can only be viewed from the outside. But it isn't hard to imagine how happy Rizal must have been to stay here with Pastor Olmer's family. It's still rural now, pretty. There's a Valley. And Dr. Rizal is said to have occupied one of the guest rooms in this vicarage. Dr. Ulmer said that the ground floor was the office of the Protestant congregation, and Dr. Rizal occupied one of the guest rooms. He developed a close bond with the pastor's children, Friedrich and Etta. What a home away from home it must have been.

Speaker 3: 20:18

Yes, gardening in the morning was the duty of the pastor's daughter was to keep the garden watered. And when Rizal moved in the guest room, Etta said, he's our guest, he eats everything, we join everything. But he also has to join me in the morning to water the plants.

Speaker 2: 20:39

But Etta in him had a bond. And that bond bloomed in the garden. Yes, based on your story that they.

Speaker 3: 20:48

Watered the plants they wanted every morning. And I think if we know about nine girlfriends of Rizal, Etta should be included in the girlfriends of Rizal probably as the Platonic love. She was probably a Platonic. Platonic love. Number 10 of Rizal.

Speaker 2: 21:16

Here in Pastor Ulmert's home he wrote chapters of the Noli me Tangere. But this period of finding both home and family was to last only months.

Speaker 1: 21:28

From San I also received in good condition everything that I had left. And therefore I thank you very much once more. May you also receive, when you are abroad, the same treatment and friendship as I have found among you. And if, being a foreigner, I can do nothing for you in a foreign country, I can be of some service to you in my homeland, where you will always find a good friend. If I do not die. Of course, the joy at being understood by other people is so great that one cannot easily forget it. You understood me too, in spite of my brown skin.

Speaker 4: 22:07

We probably presumed that there were more letters, but these are the only ones that survived. A few were postcards, and they were written after one, telling the pastor how thank you for your hospitality. I cannot reciprocate in the same way that you did. But in case you come to the Philippines, I will reciprocate there. That's presuming I don't die right away.

Speaker 2: 22:56

In October 1886, Rizal moved to Berlin. He was in the company of Maximo Viola, a Philippine doctor and writer, a close friend. To hear the scholars say it, there were two sides to Rizal's stay in Berlin.

Speaker 4: 23:18

The fact that Rizal was accepted in the Berlin ethnographic, anthropological and geographic societies meant that he wasn't, you know, for somebody who learned German for 6 years, months, and he delivered an academic paper on metrical art in this learned gathering means that he was quite exceptional in many ways. It was through Bloom and Virchow that Rizal was introduced to other academics. So Rizal introduced him to A.B. Meyer. He met Theodore Jagor, who he chatted with, because, as you know, Jagor wrote a book about his travels in the Philippines. And he was in the Philippines 1859, 1860. Shortly before Rizal was born. Jagor was the most prominent intellectual that Rizal had met. Virchow is supposed to have said, can I measure your cranium? And Rizal says, you know, yes, you may, or something. There was some funny exchange. So there is actually. Of the many pictures of Virchow, the nicest one is the one of him holding calipers and a skull, because that reminds us of that meeting he had with Jose Rizal. I have a feeling that aside from their friendship, Rizal was the culture bearer for anthropologists in a sense. I'd like to think that it was also through Bloom and Virchow that Rizal learned about to appreciate his own culture. When he lived abroad. That was the first time that he learned to appreciate his country and his culture more so talking to the scholars or talking to Virchow when they would talk about history, about anthropology, it was a way for him also to get to know his own country better. And I think that crystallized in him the whole idea of nationhood.

Speaker 2: 25:19

Finding Rizal in Germany is not only limited to tracing his journey via historic sites. In the Berlin Ethnological Museum is an important collection of indigenous textiles that trace their provenance to Rizal. I have personally seen the collection and have since dreamt of bringing the textiles to the Philippines for an exhibition. These textiles were donated by Rizal to Rudolf Virchow, a German prehistorian and anthropologist, and to Dr. Adolf Bastian, a German ethnologist and the founder of the Berlin Ethnological Museum. There are examples of Abaca and ikat weaving that still live on to this day among the Tiboli, Bagobo, Bilaan and Mandaya. Indigenous textiles which no less than our national hero was fond and proud of.

Speaker 4: 26:16

But what was interesting in this collection was that there's a beautiful carabao horn and silver salakot. Just to know that Rizal had sent his own salakot and it has been in storage in Germany for the longest time. It survived the bombing in the Second World War. It is there a testament to friendship and a testament to Philippine culture.

Speaker 2: 26:41

Another collection of a very different provenance was recently gifted to the Philippine Consulate by Dr. Fritz Haak Ulmer and family. The gift consisted of selected furniture from the guest room of Pastor Ulmer's Wilhelmsfeld home. Family lore holds that Rizal used these pieces of furniture and that the table was the very one on which the final chapters of the *Noli me tangere* were written. Today these collections link us not only to Rizal the man. They link us to the romantic ideal of a hero representing the very best of race, admired by the best and brightest of other races.

Speaker 4: 27:28

I think because of the people he was talking to Blumentritt and the other people in Germany, he learned what it was to have freedom. He was somebody who thought the Philippines as having a distinct culture and because it had a distinct culture, had to become a free and independent nation.

Speaker 2: 27:50

In stark contrast to his academic triumphs were the times of deprivation.

Speaker 4: 27:57

We are told that he could only eat once a day because he didn't have money and he subsisted on bread.

Speaker 2: 28:04

And water, as well as a frustrating search for a printer of the *Noli Metangere* in Berlin too.

Speaker 4: 28:12

They were looking for a place to print the *Noli Metangere*. A year earlier they were already looking for printers and they found out that it was very expensive. We know that Rizal completed the novel in Wilhelmsford, but I think that, you know, writing a draft is one thing and then polishing it is another. The actual polished thing was finished in Berlin in February of 1887. And then they looked for printers, and for printers they found a printing press that was run by women, so it was cheaper.

Speaker 2: 28:51

At the end of May 1887, Rizal left Germany. Before him was a long trip home to the Philippines.

Speaker 1: 29:00

He wrote, I always think of Germany. I always talk of German loyalty and integrity. When I hear German spoken, I am glad as if it were my mother tongue. I will dedicate my last farewell to Germany. I owe Germany my best remembrances.

Speaker 2: 29:25

But the journey home also marked the beginning of another, more fateful chapter in Rizal's life. It might be said that upon Rizal's arrival home in 1887, the dream of setting up a decent eye clinic, which had been nurtured and Heidelberg had to take a backseat to more urgent concerns. The publication of a *Noli Metangere* had made him a controversial source of inspiration to his countrymen and a dangerous man to the Spanish authorities.

Speaker 5: 30:18

Now it's interesting that the *Noli me tangere*, of course, is written in Spanish. So who do you think would understand the novel? The first to understand would be the friar. Back of every chapter in the novels of Rizal is an understanding of culture and civilization, of colony and empire. When you translate it into English or Tagalog, sort of vociferous friar, enemy of Rizal, understand so completely that this guy is describing him. So according to our national artist, Rio Alma, any first reading by any friar against Rizal would have to persuade himself this man must die. Just from the reading of the novel, they had already given a death sentence. To resolve.

Speaker 1: 31:37

The word no limit. Angere has been found heretical, impious and scandalous from the religious perspective, anti patriotic and subversive from the political point of view, injurious to the Spanish government and its proceedings in the Islands.

Speaker 2: 32:00

In 1888, pressured by his family and fearing for his own safety, Rizal would once again leave the Philippines. He had barely been home for six months.

Speaker 4: 32:11

In the second trip, Rizal was already, I think, crystallizing the idea of nation. The second trip is important for that. Because then, I think it was in the second trip that the idea of Filipino identity and nationhood was starting to form more clearly in his mind.

Speaker 2: 32:32

The second journey of Rizal would take him from Hong Kong to Macau and Japan, the Americas, England, then on to Spain and France, where he finished his second incendiary novel, *El Filibusterismo*.

Speaker 4: 32:59

We often see Rizal only writing the *Noli* and the *Fili*. And what we forget is that there was a second book, which was his annotated edition of Morga's 1609, *Successos de las Islas Filipinas*. If you put the three books together, you will see that Rizal rode the *Noli me tahangeret*

to tackle the present, his present. He went back into the past with the Morga and the Pili was the future.

Speaker 2: 33:30

In 1892, he would return to the land of his birth, only to face persecution, exile in the Pitang, flight to Cuba, eventual arrest, execution. In contrast to his first journey, full of joyful friendships and opportunities for learning, the second one is a story of a man's flight from political persecution to.

Speaker 4: 34:00

Counter the people who say that, you know, Rizal only wanted assimilation. You just have to know that the reason why they had to shoot him was if you give people a little bit of reform, you give them assimilation. The next step will be independence and freedom. So we don't think that Rizal would have stopped at being a province of Spain. You can see in the trajectory of his thought and his writing that is where he was going. It's just that they killed him before he got there.

Speaker 2: 34:33

Rizal lived in a time of barriers. Indio versus ilustrado, peninsulares versus insulares, ideas of masonry, revolution and enlightenment versus a decaying colonialism. Yet his first journey through Europe and his time in Germany represented an opening up of an otherwise limited world, a breaking down of barriers, a pursuit and exchange of knowledge among human beings who valued each other's abilities more than they did race and skin color.

Speaker 4: 35:20

If Bonifacio were alive and you asked him who is your hero? Bonifacio would have said its result. So we have to see the heroes us building on each other. Rizal gave an idea, Bonifacio started a revolution and gave human form to that idea. But he was not able to complete it. And even if he's the hero we all love to hate, it is Aguinaldo who brought it and gave us the first republic. A stillborn, but still the first republic.

Speaker 2: 35:54

As the pandemic forces us to radically rethink our lives. Are we not also living in a time of barriers? Physical barriers that not only have affected us at home, but also our relationships, our travels, the way in which knowledge is transmitted more easily? Educational barriers have forced many of us to see our history and the whole contributions of Rizal to world culture as irrelevant or even useless to our chaotic times. A current world trend towards populism also reinforces this view that higher learning, the lessons of history, the journeys of our heroes, all these have little place in today's political and social arena.

Speaker 5: 36:49

Because we have to link Rizal with the present condition. Because Rizal was part of what we now call a diaspora of his time, as much as there is now. A diaspora of our time. And we can understand what is now when we look at what was then.

Speaker 4: 37:13

I always like to say to see in Rizal the Filipino capacity for greatness. We're a very battered culture. We like blaming others. But when you look at Rizal, you see this oriental in Europe in the 19th century, making the most out of it and showing the best that we can be.

Speaker 2: 37:47

Rizal lived in a time of barriers, yet he broke through these to continually reaffirm his humanity and his genius as a Nation celebrates a 160th anniversary of his birth. May we find a peace of his humanity in our every journey, in every barrier we break down.